



Redcar Old Boys Football Club.
Match Report V Redcar Newmarket Away
Friendly
25/07/26
Lost 2-1

A bloke said to me recently, "I know loads of different people in life simply because of your amazing love for football Rob."

I really liked that sentiment, but the reality is my amazing love for football has been waning very quickly.

Last season's Redcar Old Boys campaign was tough. Very tough. Personally I know my playing days are numbered as I struggle more and more.

And as for the professional game, the last time I went to a Newcastle match, it was ninety quid to get in. Ninety quid! Then it was all flag waving, loud music blaring, kids holding begging banner nonsense, and the Turkish bloke sat in front of me was more bothered about making TikTok videos than any of the football.

Manchester City's bore you to death style and the diving, deliberate fouling, cheating arseholes made for a wholly unenjoyable night. And if Phil Foden had delayed the restart after a deliberate foul one more time without any intervention from the referee, I'm convinced I'd have ran on the pitch and belted the chavvy little get. I laughed when he didn't get in the world cup squad. Ha! Shithouse!

Then Arsenal and their irritating prick of a manager, go and win. Urgh! And don't get me started on VAR. And music when goals are scored. And women commentators. And PSR. And the destruction of the FA cup. And... well I could go on.

At least there was a world cup; only for that to have cheating President involvement, countdowns to the kick off, a woman in the kitchen doing tactics, barely able to speak English pundits, defending a lead for almost a whole half by the alleged tactical genius, and pissing refreshment breaks! Good God! What a load of shit.

Good old Redcar Old Boys then played Philadelphia and we were hammered, and just as I was thinking it couldn't get any worse...

Kevin Keegan died!

I became a Newcastle United fan when I was about three years old, not because anyone in the family was remotely linked to Newcastle or even that I wanted to support them, but because a Geordie family moved into our North Yorkshire street and, as the oldest kid on the block, the Geordie lad reserved the right to tell all the other kids who they were supporting. He dished out some old black and white kits and we became fans. As I grew older, the issue was this. Newcastle were rubbish! We were second division nobodies. The best I could muster was a Steve Hardwick poster from a Topical Times annual, such was our absence from Shoot and other publications. We were never on the television and an added issue was, everyone else supported Man United or Liverpool (Not Boro, even though you now claim you did!), so, while everyone revelled in the glory of success, the only reward I received for supporting Newcastle was the odd punch to the head for daring to be different.

When I was seven years old I was torn. The draw of Liverpool and Emlyn Hughes off the telly was huge.

And then Kevin Keegan signed!

I remember the moment. I was three doors down from home and my mate Danny, a fellow Newcastle recruit, poked his head through the bannister from half way down his stairs and grinned, "We've signed Keegan!" We couldn't believe it. The England captain and recent twice European

player of the year. The bloke who had records in the charts. The fella off superstars. He had signed for us. We laughed and danced and the next two years were everything I could have dreamed of and more. Posters, TV appearances, Newspaper articles and promotion followed. I was smitten. Then, in the whoosh of a helicopter blade he was gone. Waddle, Beardsley, Gascoigne and Quinn gave me worthy heroes to worship, but I never quite felt the same as I did for Special K. I was a regular at St James Park, strangely enjoying Ozzie Ardiles' approach to obliterating the club from existence, when the midday news announced that Kevin was back as manager, I was gobsmacked and overjoyed in equal measure.

Bristol City at home followed and I couldn't get into St James' any more so I watched the David Kelly relegation saving moment reported as a goal via the Granada shop window in Middlesbrough's Cleveland Centre and watched most of the promotion season on Ceefax.

A job at Harcros in Norton followed, during which two incredible events occurred.

The first, they knocked down the Gallowgate end and an announcement came over the tannoy for me, saying my mate James was on the phone asking if I wanted a half season ticket in the Gallowgate rubble. You what! I didn't need asking twice.

I didn't think life could get better than that. And then it did.

Another tannoy announcement told me I had to attend the joinery shed.

I made my way grumpily, expecting to be given a job to do. On arrival a black rover was parked right in the way. Someone was getting special treatment by being allowed to be parked there. The stocky vehicle owner stood with his back to me, surrounded by my Harcros colleagues. And then Kevin Keegan turned around and offered a hand to shake. "You must be Rob," he said. "They tell me you're a big fan."

I held out a cement covered, yellow glove which the great man shook and I managed to mumble, "I support them," as my heart was just about kicking back into sync, having been stopped for the previous thirty seconds.

"I know you support them, that's why I waited to see you," said Kevin, before, "Let's see if we can find you some stuff."

He rummaged around in his car and produced a 'Mag' belonging to his daughter Laura. He signed it and gave it to me.

Someone shouted "Andy Cole's class," and he replied that Shearer was better, and with that he drove away.

Rooted to the spot, an old lag slapped me on the back and said "You could have taken your rotten glove off to shake his hand."

Thirty-three years later I can still visualise the moment as if it was yesterday. I can even remember the song that was playing on the radio - *The Sign* by Ace of Base.

It turned out he'd been buying wood to build his daughter a bed or something. He didn't need to wait around to see me but he did because that was the kind of guy he was, and I loved him all the more for it.

In May 2022 I was lucky enough to speak to him again at a meet and greet. I mentioned the Harcros meeting. He remembered buying the wood but not me obviously. After his stage four cancer announcement, I bought tickets to see him again next February. I never really believed that he wouldn't still be with us.

The Newmarket friendly came quickly and I wasn't looking forward to it at all, only to walk into the changing room and feel a sudden surge in optimism as players were already there and getting

ready. It was great to see the lads and as new players Dassy, Danny and Gaz walked in, the feeling only got better.

We kicked off with a force nine gale blowing into our faces and from the outset Newmarket became encamped into our half, bombarding the goal with a series of corners. Despite the pressure we defended narrow as planned and it worked quite well. Other than a mishap when I misjudged a long ball in the wind to allow their left back in, who shot marginally wide, we rarely looked like we might concede. Sadly we did. Their winger came inside and stayed onside to run clean through the middle, with Shane rooted to his line, presumably conscious of wind assisted, lobbing opportunities, from distance.

At one-nil down we started to play a bit and Russ tested the keeper well, Jonathan fired high over the bar and Foxy nearly put a shot out for a throw, though it didn't even manage to go out. In fairness, Newmarket had chances of their own and we were lucky on a few offside calls, twice caused by me being caught napping, though it still felt really unfortunate when they scored a second from a corner right at the death of the half.

I couldn't see what happened properly but it clearly caused some finger pointing and upset that carried over into half time. I actually noticed a little griping when we conceded the first too. Most people know when they could have done better and feel bad about it, without some blame placer adding to that angst. For me that whinging was the only real team negative of the day.

We reshuffled every ten minutes and continued with a stream of substitutions, yet this week, people seemed to slot back in seamlessly and Gaz made his debut and looked excellent against a very tricky opponent. With wind assistance, (which significantly died down from the first half,) we started to apply some pressure of our own and Dassy and then John looked like they would score, only to not get fully behind their shots. Kev ran clean through too but unfortunately someone had filled his boots with concrete and he couldn't reach the ball as it rolled out to safety.

Newmarket were still dangerous of course and Shane made three or four good saves, handling perfectly.

Our breakthrough came late as Dassy danced through players, looked like he might pass twice, but was frantically waved on by John, and then slotted it home. It was a lovely, well deserved goal, and from that point we hemmed them in and I felt sure we'd equalise.

A wicked Danny corner was inches from being headed in by everyone, including the Newmarket players but then it was them who had the best two chances as we pressed men forward, hitting the post with one, when they should have scored.

We sadly ran out of time and didn't score again but despite the defeat, there was very encouraging signs. Last season we turned a narrow defeat in this fixture into a first game win. Let's do the same this year!

I had to dash at the end to go out, so missed the after match chat, but I expect it was positive. Personally I was buzzing at the end that we did so well against a team three divisions higher than us. It only takes one good game and you see, deep down, despite the best efforts of this modern world, when it comes to football...

It looks like I'm falling, all over again. Head over heels in love.

RIP Kevin.

Positives: We looked Newmarket's equals for large periods.

Negatives: Gripping. No need.

Man of the Match: Michael Dass. (My choice)

